Chapter-wise Detailed Notes — Protective discrimination and fairness

Introduction to Political Theory · Unit 5 · Chapter Protective discrimination and fairness

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Chapter Study Notes

Learning focus

Protective discrimination refers to measures designed to address historical exclusion or structural disadvantage, including reservations or targeted support where provided by law.

1. Supporters argue that formally equal rules may preserve unequal outcomes when people face entrenched barriers. Corrective measures can improve representation, opportunity and dignity.

2. Critics raise questions about targeting, duration, implementation, economic criteria, elite capture and the relationship between group disadvantage and individual circumstances.

3. Fair evaluation asks whether the measure addresses a demonstrated disadvantage, is constitutionally and legally grounded, is proportionate to its aim and is reviewed using credible evidence.

4. In India, affirmative-action questions must be analysed with the relevant constitutional provisions and applicable judgments rather than simplified slogans.

Revision checklist

■ Can I define the key concept in my own words?

■ Can I explain its main features and distinguish it from related concepts?

■ Can I support an argument with a relevant example, thinker or constitutional provision?

■ Can I discuss at least one limitation or counterargument?